



Evolving Strategies

Companies need to adapt to changing times for a strong workforce

By **Devashish Sharma**

FORCE = MASS X ACCELERATION. Don't worry. You have not stumbled upon a page from a physics journal. But a few days ago, when I was discussing something with my son around the applications of this formula, it struck me that while we have known this forever—a strong force doesn't just need more mass, but more acceleration too. When it comes to our workforce, we often assume that those ancient HR policies, tenure-based growth and learning mechanisms of our beloved hierarchical systems will help us have a strong workforce. We forget that while the basics need to be in place, some things need to change for the workforce to grow—not in numbers, but in value and impact.

The shift in our workforce's preferences, from Gen X to Gen Z, reiterates this thought. In the past few years, their evolving preferences have highlighted a dynamic mindset that refuses to conform to the age-old definition of an employee-employer relationship.

The BT-Taggd annual survey of 'The Best Companies to Work For in India' yet again unveils what those factors are. In this survey, we engaged with over 43,000 employees across 1,600 organisations and 11 industries, uncovering the pulse of modern working India's desires. Among the myriad insights, four overarching themes have emerged.

TRANSPARENCY: CORNERSTONE OF EMPLOYEE SATISFACTION

According to latest findings, a staggering 70% of Gen Z and millennial workers prioritise fair and open processes when selecting employers. This demand for transparency extends across age groups, with 65% of millennial employees (30-50 years old) and 60% of Gen X (over 50 years) considering it a crucial part of their employment.

FLEXIBILITY TO DRIVE DIVERSITY

Flexibility emerges as a key priority for women employees and senior professionals alike. For 38% of women, the ability to flexibly balance work with other responsibilities is paramount, driving the demand for flexible work arrangements, though men are not far behind. One out of three men preferred flexibility in their working hours and the place of work.

Similarly, 42% of Gen X employees seek projects that offer them flexibility, signalling a desire for more autonomy. By accommodating these needs, organisations can tap into a diverse talent pool and foster a culture of inclusivity and empowerment.

EMBRACING THE GIG ECONOMY

The gig economy continues to see massive traction, fuelled by government social security initiatives, growing demand in some white-collar industries, and the allure of flexibility.

Concerns among employers that gig work usually translates to low-quality deliverables and that there is a dearth of skilled gig professionals are fading away. Almost 53% of IT professionals plan to switch to gig work due to flexibility and pay advantages.

Going the gig way can especially help companies bridge short-term skill gaps in their workforce in niche fields with wide demand-supply mismatches.

GENERATIVE AI: FROM THREAT TO ALLY

The initial perception of Generative AI as a threat to human jobs is fading, replaced by recognition of its potential as a productivity-enhancing tool.

However, realising its benefits requires companies to develop upskilling and training initiatives—an area where serious heavy lifting is needed. Less than 50% of employees mentioned that they get training support from their employers, whereas 10% said their employers are not supporting them. With the penetration of Gen AI, the current state is worrisome, and employers would need to do a lot more to empower their employees.

As companies prepare to meet their growth goals, they need a stronger workforce. Like the physics equation, our workforce, too, has that recipe for success. It is crucial that organisations use these insights to attune their people's practices and policies if they are aiming for a stronger workforce. **BT**

The writer is CEO and Founding Member, Taggd